PRD: Letters Between Student and Parent

Oct 16, 2026 · @Audrey

A sealed letter, sent as often as each family's onboarding suggests, that lets immigrant and international art students show what their work really took, and lets their families answer with care and share their own story back. This PRD scopes the prototype and lists the questions to answer before building it. It was revised after the October 16 problem analysis.

Problem and belief

Parents read outcomes as a measure of effort. When a grade or critique falls short of their expectations, students feel accused of not trying hard enough, so they stop sharing and say "I'm fine."

In art, effort and outcome are loosely linked. Critiques are subjective, progress is slow, and setbacks like visa delays are out of the student's control. So the part of the story that would answer the accusation, what the work took, is exactly the part parents never see.

Parents carry a hidden middle too: the sacrifice behind their expectations, which children rarely hear about. Both sides want the same thing, but neither sees what it took for the other.

Belief: we all want the same things, but the middle of the story gets lost. Emotional connection requires sharing the process, not just the outcome, in both directions.

Audience: immigrant and international art students and their families. Many families are both, for example an immigrant family whose child now studies abroad. The product can't assume the family lives far apart or under one roof.

Product in one line: as often as their onboarding suggests, either person sends a sealed letter built from a few short prompts about their week, answered by photo, video, text or icons. Students can choose to show themselves working so parents see the process. After a semester, the thread becomes a digital recap, like a Spotify recap.

Decisions so far

The team settled these on October 16. Every section below matches them.

Question	Decision	Effect on the prototype
Who can write	Either person can write a letter; nobody can demand one	Parents get their own compose entry point
Letter structure	The app suggests prompts from a personalized library; the student picks which and how many to answer. Any prompt can be skipped.	Compose shows suggested prompts with a skip option; see the prompt library tab
Response options	Every prompt can be answered by photo, video, text or icons; the student's preferred mode appears first but never restricts the choice	Four options on every prompt, one marked "Suggested"
Showing the process	Optional. Students can share themselves working so parents see what the work takes	An optional "show me working" item in compose
What I need	Encouragement, someone to listen, advice, support, space, a distraction, or a little piece of home	Shown clearly when the parent opens the letter
Parent letter	Uses the same prompt library as students; parents can share their own issues and say what they need	The same compose flow as students, with prompts picked from the parent's onboarding
Onboarding profile	Five multiple-choice questions each. The student's answers set topic, type of moment, tone and the cue parents see; the parent's answers set interest, connection, frequency, natural response and worries.	Onboarding screens with tappable options

Question	Decision	Effect on the prototype
Student comfort first	When the two profiles conflict, the student's comfort wins. Parent preferences never add check-ins, override boundaries or reveal what the student didn't share.	Parent frequency is a suggestion only
Parent response cues	A short cue when a parent opens a letter, based on how the student wants them to respond and any mismatch with the parent's instinct	A cue line above the reply options
Pulse	Can be sent anytime: a sound and an "I'm thinking of you". No scheduled pulses; they would feel insincere.	A widget screen with no reply prompt and no read receipt
Reply mode	Parents reply by voice, text or photo	The reply screen shows all three options equally
Platform	iPhone only	All hero screens are iOS
Delivery	An App Clip inside iMessage; the first tap opens the letter	Screen 5 shows the App Clip card and the opened letter
Parent download hook	Without the app, a parent sees only the letter; at its end, a prompt says to download the app for history and recap	A download prompt at the end of the opened letter
Recap content	Letters, voice notes, photos, words, stats, and when each letter was sent	Recap screens built from these
Keepsake	A digital recap in the style of a Spotify recap, not a printed book	Recap screens replace the book layout
Favorites	Private to the person who saved them	No "saved" signal to the other person
Widget	Placement is the user's choice: home screen, lock screen or both	Show one placement in the prototype

Question	Decision	Effect on the prototype
Language	English only; translation is out of scope	No translation UI
Distress	Responding to a letter that reveals distress is out of scope	Stated as out of scope in the video if asked
Audience	Immigrant and international art students and their families, including families that are both	The hero family is both immigrant and international
Letters explain, never defend	Nothing counts hours, grades or output; artifacts show the work, not prove it	No proof-of-work fields anywhere in compose
Schedule sharing	Kept, optional and student-controlled. Sources: Google Calendar, Apple Calendar, a course portal or a manual upload. The student chooses what shows, can hide single events or pause, and parents never see that something is hidden.	An opt-in toggle in the connect flow and a schedule card for parents
Rhythm	How often prompts arrive depends on onboarding: the parent's preferred frequency, shaped by the student's barrier and comfort. When they conflict, the student's boundary wins.	No fixed weekly letter; cadence differs per family
Visibility and skipping	Both people can see every letter between them. Either person can skip a prompt, and either can skip a whole letter.	A shared letter history; skip options on prompts and letters for both sides

Question	Decision	Effect on the prototype
Offensive content	An automatic check at sealing flags insults, shaming, hate, threats and guilt-tripping. The sender is asked to send anyway or rewrite; if sent, the reader gets a warning and chooses whether to open it. Like a messaging app, either person can delete a letter, pause the connection, or disconnect, and the sender is told.	A pause-and-ask sheet at sealing; a warning envelope; delete, pause and disconnect options

Schedule sharing is the feature closest to monitoring, and it gives parents more outcome data to judge effort by. It stays only if testing shows students feel safe with it.

Users and what we learned

Students and parents want the same things, but each sees only part of the other's story. These rows come from the team's interview outline. Quotes and counts from the real interviews still need to be added.

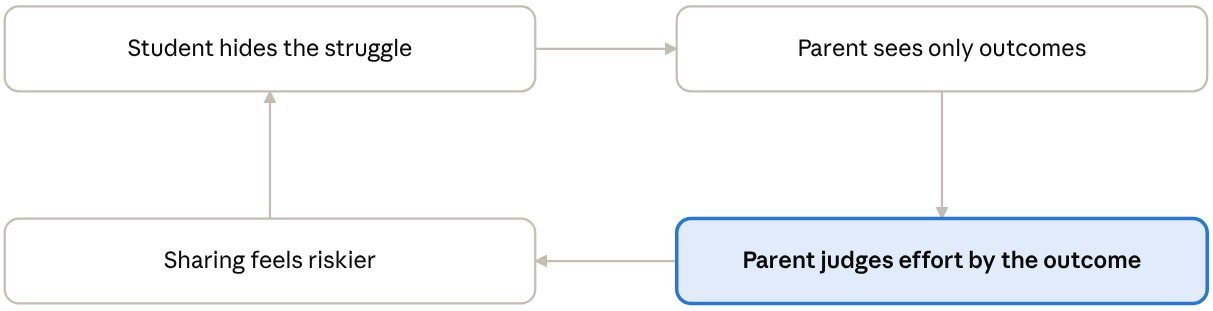
	Immigrant or international art student	Parent
Wants	Mutual trust; "I want you to believe I can do this"; "I'm trying my best"	To know their child is okay, and that the sacrifice was worth it
What they see	The full process: critiques, rework, visa stress	Outcomes: grades, jobs, polished posts
What they hide	Struggle, because a weak outcome reads as "you didn't try"	Their own sacrifice, worry and loneliness
How they read the other	"They only care about results"	"If the result isn't good, the effort wasn't enough"
Default behavior	Says "I'm fine" and shares only good news	Worries, gives advice, asks about results, or goes quiet

	Immigrant or international art student	Parent
What the product gives them	A safe way to show what the work took and say what they need	A way to see the effort, respond with care, and share their own story

Shared insight: a parent's pressure and a student's silence are two forms of the same care. Each hides their middle to protect the other.

The loop the product has to break:

Each side protects the other, and the gap grows



The need picker and pause prompt break the loop here

the silence loop · 4 steps

Prompts and the optional "show me working" item make the struggle visible; the need picker and pause prompt change how the parent reads it.

Product principles

The competition rewards opinionated products, so every feature must pass one test: does it serve the belief, or is it just a good idea?

Trait	In this product
Clear belief	Emotional connection requires sharing the process, not just the outcome, in both directions

Trait	In this product
Explains, never defends	A letter shows what something took so the reader can understand it, not to prove effort. Artifacts show the work; they never serve as alibis.
Intentional constraints	Letters paced by each family's onboarding, never an endless stream; a few short prompts, each one skippable; no live chat
Behavior-changing interactions	Parents answer what their child asked for (listen, support or advice), not the outcome
Recognizable identity	A sealed letter and a semester-long recap, not another generic chat app

Every prompt, label and artifact must pass one check: **does this help someone understand, or help someone prove?** If it helps someone prove, cut it.

Constraints we will not break

- **Either person can write; nobody can demand.** No reminders aimed at the other person, no streaks, no "you haven't written" nudges. Encouragement from the app goes only to the writer.
- **Student comfort comes first.** When the two profiles conflict, the student's boundaries win; parent preferences shape relevance, never pressure.
- **Every prompt can be skipped,** and showing the process is always optional.
- **The letter explains, it never defends.** No hour counts, no grade fields, no proof-of-work prompts.
- **Profiles are never shown as labels.** Onboarding answers only change prompts and cues.
- **No read receipts, no dashboards, no location tracking.** A shared schedule is the one exception, and only because the student opts in and chooses what shows.
- **Letters and replies arrive sealed,** never as a live back-and-forth.

Scope

The prototype shows about six moments with real craft; everything else is a line in the video. This split comes from the team's flow and our analysis, and the interviews should override it.

Feature	Call	Why
Student letter built from suggested prompts the student picks (photo, video, text, icons), each skippable	Core	The belief made tangible, with low effort on hard weeks
Optional "show me working" item	Core	Lets parents see the process without making it a requirement
"What I need" picker: listen, support, advice	Core	Changes how parents reply, which keeps students sharing
Parent opens a sealed letter and replies	Core	The emotional payoff and the best footage
Reply by voice, text or photo	Core	The parent picks the mode; voice carries tone
Parent's letter from the shared library, including their own issues	Core	Makes the belief work both ways; explains where the expectations come from
Delivery by App Clip in iMessage	Core	Parents open the first letter without installing anything
Download prompt at the end of the letter	Core	Adoption is the weakest link
Digital recap keepsake, Spotify style	Core	Identity and long-term payoff
Onboarding profiles for student and parent	Supporting	Drives prompt suggestions and parent cues; show one example
Parent response cues	Supporting	Helps parents answer what the student actually needs
Pulse widget	Supporting	A sincere, one-tap sign of care, sent anytime; never asks for a reply

Feature	Call	Why
Connect with a parent or family	Supporting	Needed for the flow; keep it to one screen
Save favorite notes (private)	Supporting	Feeds the recap
Monthly recap	Supporting	Makes the habit visible; a smaller version of the semester keepsake
"How to help" card for parents	Supporting	Gives anxious parents something concrete to do besides advise
Shared schedule (opt-in)	Supporting	Context for parents; stays student-controlled
Translation	Out of scope	English only for now

Requirements by flow

Each requirement follows the team's flow. Items marked *to define* depend on the open questions at the end.

1. Onboarding and communication style

- Student and parent each answer five multiple-choice questions (see Onboarding and prompt logic).
- The student's answers set the prompt topic, the type of moment, the tone and difficulty, and the cue the parent sees. The parent's answers add interest, connection preference, suggested frequency, natural response and worries.
- Answers change prompt suggestions and cues, never the student's control over what and when to share.
- Profiles are never shown as labels to the user, and everything can be changed later.

2. Connect with a parent, child or family

- Either person can invite family members through Messages.
- The invited person sees who invited them and what the app is for before doing anything.
- An optional schedule-sharing toggle appears for students only, off by default.

- *To define:* how a connection is accepted, and whether a student can connect two parents or a sibling.

3. Student writes a letter

- The app suggests prompts from the personalized library; the student picks which ones, and how many, to answer.
- Every prompt offers photo, video, text and icons. The student's preferred mode is marked "Suggested" but never restricts the choice.
- Any prompt can be skipped. The app never requires a minimum.
- An optional "show me working" item lets the student share a photo, video or note of the process. No fields count hours, grades or output.
- "What I need" closes the letter: encouragement, someone to listen, advice, support, space, a distraction, or a little piece of home.
- Preview as the parent will see it, then seal and send.

4. Parent writes a letter

- Parents draw prompts from the same library as students, picked from their own onboarding answers, and answer by photo, video, text or icons.
- Parents can share their own issues and say what they need, the same way students do.
- Sealed and delivered the same way as a student's letter.

5. Delivery through Messages

- iPhone only. The letter is sent from the iMessage app drawer and arrives as a sealed envelope.
- A recipient without the app opens it as an App Clip: the first tap opens the letter, with nothing to install.

6. Open and reply

- The reader opens the sealed letter and sees the answers, the optional "show me working" item, and what the writer needs.
- A parent response cue sits above the reply options, for example "They may just want you to hear them" or "A simple acknowledgment may be enough right now". It comes from how the student wants family to respond, and gets stronger when the parent's instinct differs.

- A short pause prompt before replying slows the advice reflex (proposed; to be tested).
- The reply is one free response by voice, text or photo, and arrives sealed.

7. Pulse widget

- A one-tap pulse from a widget plays a sound and shows "I'm thinking of you". Either person can send one anytime.
- Pulses are never scheduled or automatic: each one is sent by a person in the moment, so it stays sincere.
- Each user chooses where the widget lives: home screen, lock screen or both.
- A pulse never asks for a reply and has no read receipt (*to define:* whether there is a daily limit).

8. Favorites and recap

- Either person can save favorite notes; favorites are private.
- A monthly recap collects letters, voice notes, photos, words, stats, and when each letter was sent.
- The semester keepsake is a digital, Spotify-style recap built from the same material (*to define:* structure, and how voice notes play).

9. Parent adoption

- Without the app, a parent sees only the letter that was sent.
- At the end of the letter, a prompt says: download the app to see your history and recap.

10. Shared schedule (optional)

- A student can link Google Calendar, Apple Calendar, a course portal or a manual upload.
- The student chooses what shows (busy blocks, class names or deadlines), can hide single events, and can pause or stop at any time.
- Parents never see that something is hidden or paused.
- Parents see a quiet card beside the letter, never an alert, and it never replaces the letter.

11. Offensive content

- **What counts:** insults and shaming (about grades, effort or choices), hateful language, threats or abuse, and guilt or pressure used as a weapon ("after everything we sacrificed"). This applies in both directions.
- **Detection:** an automatic check runs when a letter or reply is sealed. In the prototype, this is mocked.
- **Pause and ask:** if the check flags something, the sender sees a prompt ("This might land hard. Send anyway, or rewrite?"). Nothing is blocked; the sender decides.
- **Warning for the reader:** if the sender sends it anyway, it arrives with a gentle warning, and the reader chooses whether to open it.
- **Controls, like a messaging app:** either person can delete a letter, pause the connection for a while, or disconnect. There is no reporting or outside review.
- **The sender is told:** when a letter arrived with a warning, was deleted by the reader, or the connection was paused, the sender sees it, as they would in a messaging app.

Onboarding and prompt logic

The app suggests prompts by combining both profiles, and the student's comfort always comes first. The full library of 24 prompt categories is in the Prompt library tab.

Full library: Prompt library

Student onboarding

#	Question	Options	What it sets
1	What do you wish your family understood more about your life away from home?	My everyday routine; The work behind my accomplishments; When I'm stressed or overwhelmed; The small things that make me happy; New experiences and people in my life; How I'm growing and becoming more independent	Prompt topic

#	Question	Options	What it sets
2	What do you usually like sharing with your family?	Photos or moments from my day; Funny or random things; Things I'm proud of; Challenges I'm going through; Major updates only	Type of moment
3	How do you prefer to share updates?	Photo; Video; Text; Icons; It depends	Which response option is suggested first; never restricts the choice
4	What usually stops you from sharing more?	I don't want them to worry; I'm too busy; I don't know what to say; It feels too small to mention; I like processing things on my own first	Tone and effort of the prompt
5	When you share something difficult, how would you like your family to respond?	Just listen; Encourage me; Ask questions; Give advice; Help me solve it; Give me space	The cue the parent sees

Parent onboarding

#	Question	Options	What it sets
1	What do you wish you knew more about your student's life away from home?	What their everyday life looks like; How they're really feeling; What they're working hard on; The challenges they're facing; Their new experiences; How they're growing and becoming independent	Topic interest, matched against the student's answer
2	What kinds of updates make you feel most connected?	Everyday moments; Photos from their life; Hearing their voice; Stories about what happened; Hearing how they feel; Celebrating accomplishments	Connection preference; never overrides the student's comfort

#	Question	Options	What it sets
3	How often would you like to hear from them?	A little every day; A few times a week; About once a week; Whenever they feel like sharing	Suggested prompt frequency; never a requirement for the student
4	When your student shares something difficult, what is your first instinct?	Listen; Reassure them; Ask questions; Give advice; Help solve the problem; Give them space	Compared with the student's answer to find a mismatch
5	What usually makes you worry when you're apart?	Not hearing from them for a while; Not knowing how they're feeling; Only hearing about problems after they happen; Not knowing what their everyday life looks like; Not knowing if they need support	Prompt types that ease the worry without surveillance

How a prompt is chosen

Each candidate prompt is ranked in this order:

1. **Student comfort:** what the student is comfortable discussing and sharing.
2. **Shared interest:** a topic both the student wants understood and the parent wants to understand.
3. **Student barrier:** framing that makes the prompt easier to answer.
4. **Parent connection preference:** the kind of update that helps the parent feel connected.
5. **Variety:** not too many prompts from one category in a row.

The app suggests; the student picks. The goal is a prompt that reads as "here's a small moment you might want to share," never "your parent wants an update."

Parent response cues

Student wants family to	Cue the parent sees
Just listen	"They may just want you to hear them."

Student wants family to	Cue the parent sees
Encourage me	"A little encouragement may mean more than advice."
Ask questions	"They're open to you asking more."
Give advice	"They're open to hearing your perspective."
Help me solve it	"They may appreciate help thinking through next steps."
Give me space	"A simple acknowledgment may be enough right now."

When the two profiles don't match

Parent says	Student says	What the app does
A little every day	I'm too busy	No added pressure; ultra-low-effort prompts and icon answers
Give advice	Just listen	Normal prompts for the student; the parent sees "They may be sharing this to feel heard rather than looking for a solution."
Worries when they don't know how the student is	I don't want them to worry	Balanced prompts: one challenge and one thing that's helping
How they're really feeling	Photos and moments from my day	Indirect emotional prompts, such as "What part of your day matched your mood today?"
Wants to hear about challenges as they happen	I like processing things first	Reflective prompts, such as "Looking back on the past few days, what's something you feel ready to share now?"

Prompt mix over time

The mix keeps the experience from getting emotionally heavy, and shifts with onboarding answers and engagement.

Category	Share of prompts
Everyday life	35%
Positive moments	20%
Behind the outcome	15%
Reflection and growth	10%
Challenges	10%
Connection to home	10%

Worked example. A student wants family to understand stress, shares challenges, doesn't want them to worry, and wants them to just listen. Their parent wants to know how they feel, connects through voice, and tends to problem-solve. The app suggests "What's been taking up your energy lately, and what's helping you through it?" and the parent sees "They may just want you to listen and understand what this week has been like."

Prototype spec

The video carries most of the grade, and the prototype doesn't have to work, but it must look like real, designed software. Polish the hero screens fully and keep the rest as simple, honest frames.

#	Screen	Must show	Level
1	Onboarding: communication style	Two or three of the onboarding questions, and the next screen's prompts changing as a result	Light
2	Connect with family	Invite through iMessage, who sees what, optional schedule toggle (off by default)	Light

#	Screen	Must show	Level
3	Student writes a letter	Suggested prompts the student picks from, each with photo, video, text and icons and a skip; the optional "show me working" item; "what I need"	Hero
4	Preview and seal	The letter as the parent will see it; the sealing moment	Hero
5	iMessage delivery	The sealed letter arriving as an App Clip card; the first tap opening it	Hero
6	Parent opens	The unsealing moment, the answers and "show me working", "what I need" shown clearly, the parent response cue, and the download prompt at the end	Hero
7	Parent replies	Pause prompt; voice, text and photo shown equally	Hero
8	Parent's letter	A parent answering a prompt from the shared library, and the student opening it	Light
9	Pulse widget	The widget and the one-tap send with sound	Light
10	Favorites and monthly recap	Private saved notes; a month shown as a journey	Light
11	Keepsake preview	A digital, Spotify-style recap of the semester	Hero

The deadline is Monday, October 19, with 3 people building screens. Plan for low fidelity first: cut screens 1, 2, 9 and 10 to single frames and spend the craft on 3 to 7 and 11. Screen 8 should stay: it's the only place the video shows the belief working both ways.

Platform note: the prototype is iPhone only. A parent without the app opens the letter as an App Clip, with nothing to install. Show the App Clip card as Apple presents it, and label anything that is mocked.

Tests and success measures

Evidence matters more than claims here. Each test should leave a moment we can show in the video, including one that failed and what we changed.

Run test 1 first, before any screens. It checks the two bets everything else depends on, using only iMessage.

#	Test	Who	What we watch	Success looks like
1	Paper letter (no app)	3 student–parent pairs; the student answers three prompts from the library and sends them over iMessage	Whether the student shares a real setback; whether the parent's reply matches the stated need	At least 2 of 3 students share a setback; at least 2 of 3 replies answer the need, not the outcome
2	Write a letter from prompts	3 to 5 art students	Where they hesitate, which prompts they skip, whether they add "show me working", whether they soften the truth at preview	Most finish in under 5 minutes and say the letter shows more than "I'm fine"
3	Explains or defends	The letters from tests 1 and 2, read by the team	Whether "what it took" reads as explanation or as justification	Most letters explain; any that defend tell us which prompt to change
4	Open and reply cold	3 to 5 parents on their own phones, no instructions	Whether they open it unaided, which reply mode they pick, where they ask what to press	Parents reach a reply without help
5	Voice versus text	The same parent hears a note, then reads it	Whether the reply changes in tone or content	A parent names something they heard in the voice that text would have hidden

#	Test	Who	What we watch	Success looks like
6	"What I need" effect	Parents, with and without the need and pause prompts	Whether the reply matches listen, support or advice	Replies shift from outcome questions toward what the student asked for
7	Parent's letter	3 parents	Whether they write about themselves, and what their child feels reading it	At least one student says they understand their parent's expectations better
8	Parent download hook	Parents after their first reply	Whether they want to keep the letters in an app	Parents ask to save letters or see the recap

Measures to report in the video:

- Share of parents who replied without help
- Share of students who chose listen or support rather than advice
- Share of replies that matched the stated need
- One before-and-after quote per test

Consent: everyone on camera agrees to be recorded and knows the footage may be shared publicly.

Risks and assumptions

The competition asks us to state assumptions as assumptions, so each row is a bet we say out loud and test. The first two carry the whole product.

Assumption or risk	Why it matters	How we check it
Students will share the real middle, not a curated version	If they skip every hard prompt, the product reproduces the gap	Test 1, and which prompts get skipped in test 2

Assumption or risk	Why it matters	How we check it
A stated need changes how parents reply	Behavior change is the core claim; one outcome-focused reply ends the habit	Tests 1 and 6
Letters will explain, not defend	If "show me working" becomes proof of work, students feel watched again	Test 3; keep it optional
Parents will write about themselves	The two-way belief depends on it	Test 7
Parent preferences turn into pressure	A parent who picks "a little every day" could make prompts feel like obligations	Student comfort wins every conflict; frequency is only a suggestion
Parent cues feel preachy	A cue that reads as a lecture may annoy parents	Watch parents' reactions to the cue in test 4
Onboarding feels like being sorted	People dislike being put in boxes	Never show profiles as labels; ask testers how the suggestions feel
"Either can write" won't become pressure to write back	Pressure breaks the no-demand constraint	Ask both sides; encouragement goes only to the writer
Parents will open a letter from their child and reply	Adoption is the weakest link	Test 4
Parents want to download an app	The download prompt depends on it	Test 8, asked after the first reply, not before
Pulses sent anytime become noise	Sound plus frequent pulses can wear thin	Watch how often testers send them
App Clip delivery works as shown	The prototype may promise more than iMessage allows	Label prototype-only parts
English-only excludes some parents	Many immigrant parents are more at ease in another language	Note it in the video as a next step

Assumption or risk	Why it matters	How we check it
A regular rhythm will stick	Rituals fade quickly, and hard weeks are when writing is least likely	Low-effort and icon prompts keep a letter short; the recap gives a reason to continue
Shared schedule feels like monitoring	It gives parents more outcome data to judge effort by	Opt-in, student-controlled, hidden events stay invisible; ask students directly
The offensive-content check misfires	Guilt and pressure are hard to judge; flagging a loving but blunt parent could feel like the app taking sides	The check only asks and never blocks; read flagged examples with families in testing

Open questions

Answered questions now live in the decisions table, the flows and the onboarding section. These remain, and none of them blocks the Monday prototype.

A. Brand and craft

1. What is the product called, and what is the tagline? Not decided yet.
2. What is the visual feel? To decide after the low-fidelity screens.

B. Evidence

3. The interview footage exists: how many students and parents, and which quotes go into the Users section?
4. Test 1 will run before filming: who are the 3 pairs, and when do their letters and replies come back?